



PINNING UP HOPE: Passport copies tied to an old peepal tree

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The Baba of Big Dreams

Devotees pin up copies of passports at the shrine of a 'Passport Peer' to seek divine help to go abroad

■ By Nityanand Shukla

Serpentine queues of young men waiting with copies of their passports in their hands outside a shrine in Kallu Bagan in Jamshedpur will make one wonder if there's an embassy or a ticket counter of an airline in the vicinity. But no, people come here to offer their prayers at the shrine of Miskin Shah Baba, popularly known 'Passport Baba', and seek divine intervention in their efforts to cross the seas. It is believed that if someone who wants to go abroad comes here and ties a copy of his or her passport on the old peepal tree inside the shrine as an offering, he or she is bound to see the dream of going abroad fulfilled in no time.

Peer Mohammad, the caretaker of the shrine, says, "People of all faiths come here from far-flung areas to pray and offer a copy of their passport which they pin on to the peepal tree at his shrine. They believe that rest will soon fall in place." Miskin Baba is thought to be especially gracious to students and the unemployed. "My brother Kabir wanted to go to Saudi Arabia in search of a better job. He tied a photocopy of his passport here at the shrine and Baba fulfilled his wish. Now, he is well settled there," says Mohammad Altaf, elder brother of Mohammad Kabir.

Besides those who want to fly to foreign shores, who are in search of a job, or who want to pass their exams with fly-



ing colours and few who want to unite with their beloved, also believe in the power of this shrine. So there are not just copies of passports but also admit cards, examination hall tickets, and love letters festooned to the peepal tree. They believe Baba will take care of the rest.

According to the locals, Passport Baba who came from Lahore some 150 years ago, possessed divine powers. A shrine was constructed in his memory in 1934 in between a peepal and a banyan tree, and it is believed that anyone who comes here has his or her prayers answered. Like Paramjeet Singh whose wife was suffering from paralysis and even the best medical treatment had failed to cure her. "It was painful to see her suffer so I came here at Baba's shrine and wished for her recovery. And his blessings did wonders. My wife is much better now," he says.

Those anticipating divine blessings have to follow a system here—wishes can be pinned up only on Mondays, Thursdays and Fridays, and thereafter, one has to come to the shrine for seven consecutive weeks, without fail. There's a system even for those who cannot travel. They simply send letters, along with the copies of their passports, praying to the Baba which Mohammad hangs on the peepal tree.

So all those passport holders who are waiting for their flights of fancy, only a detour to Jamshedpur has to be taken first!